



Selection tilt: Shardul Thakur may have scored a century in the intra-squad game, but Nitish Kumar Reddy is still favoured to take the seam-bowling all-rounder's spot in the XI. GETTY IMAGES

the 2021 tour, and the 31-year-old is better suited to do the job as a first-change bowler.

India's bid to identify its third pacer could be informed by its search for a new-ball bowler who can make the most of the conditions and the Dukes ball early on. While Akash has

shown a penchant for making early inroads in his limited experience, he is yet to prove himself outside India and endured a tough tour of Australia, where he averaged 54 in two Tests. Arshdeep's new-ball prowess and left-arm angle could earn him a maiden Test cap, but his average of almost 42 during his five-match County Championship stint with Kent doesn't inspire confidence. Moreover, Arshdeep has a reputation for lacking consistency in managing the old ball and is ineffective once it loses its sheen. Still,

New-ball test: With Prasidh Krishna in the XI, Mohammed Siraj may have to take on more new-ball duties — an area that hasn't always played to his strengths. GETTY IMAGES

with a 'Bazballing' England likely to field at least five right-handed batters in its top eight, Arshdeep can make a strong case for himself. Owing to his natural angle and ability to swing the ball both ways, his numbers against right-handers (bowling average 21.93) see a significant improvement

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